understanding, but what he does not yet have is courage—courage to solve the German question. If he resolves this problem, he will rise to the heights," pontificated Khrushchev. He then resumed his threats of nuclear war: "We will put him in a situation where it is necessary to solve it. We will give him a choice—to go to war or sign a peace treaty." With his ballistic missiles now targeting Western Europe but not yet America, Khrushchev believed that the Europeans would stop the Americans from starting a war. "War in this day and age means no Paris and no France, all in the space of an hour," declared Khrushchev. "It's been a long time since you could spank us like a little boy—now we can swat your ass."[6]

Khrushchev was trying to use Kennedy's concern about nuclear war not only to "solve" the Berlin problem but also to prevail upon him to show "courage" and not attack Cuba once he learned of the nuclear missiles on the island. "[A]s to Cuba," stated Khrushchev, "here is an area that could really lead to some unexpected consequences." He admitted that the Soviets had provided Castro with modern weapons but stressed that "he needs [them] for defense." "However," continued Khrushchev, "if you attack Cuba, that would create an entirely different situation." A minute later he explained what he meant: "You have surrounded us with military bases. If you attack Cuba, then we will attack one of the countries next to us where you have placed your bases." It was a threat against the American installations in Turkey and Europe. The Cuban leadership would be informed by Moscow that at his meeting with Udall, Khrushchev had warned the American "without any hint of propaganda about all the consequences which could result from its treacherous actions towards Cuba."[7]

The meeting was followed by a dinner attended by Soviet officials, including the leading Soviet Cuba expert, Anastas Mikoyan. A few weeks later he would summarize the Soviet negotiating tactics as follows: "We let the Americans know that we wanted to solve the question of Berlin in the nearest future. This was done in order to distract their attention away from Cuba. So, we used a diversionary maneuver. In reality we had no intention of resolving the Berlin question at that time." Ironically, Mikoyan believed that the Americans were also using Berlin as a decoy in their Cuba game. "When the Americans learned about the transport of strategic weapons to